

Rockets

Rockets carry satellites and people into space. A rocket burns fuel to produce a jet of gas. The hot gas expands rapidly and is blasted downwards causing a force (the thrust) to push the rocket up.

Birth of the rocket

The first liquid-fuelled rocket was launched in 1926 by an American, Robert Goddard. It reached 12.5 m (41 ft). The flight lasted 2.5 seconds.



A nose cone, or fairing, reduces air resistance as the rocket takes off.

Launch of the *Long March 2C* rocket from the Jiuquan Space Centre, China, on August 19, 1983. Its main cargo was a photographic imaging satellite.

Vostok 1 spaceship



First in space

The first person in space was the Russian cosmonaut, Yuri Gagarin. He was sent up in *Vostok 1* on April 12, 1961 for a 108-minute flight.

On return, Yuri Gagarin parachuted from the *Vostok 1* capsule 7 km (just over 4 miles) above the ground.

Long March 2C was 35.1 m (115 ft) long and 3.3 m (11 ft) wide.